



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Good Shepherd School
School Website: <https://goodshepherdschoolva.com/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Good Shepherd School Va 20134 presents a coherent classical-education profile tightly integrated with Catholic formation. Public-facing materials repeatedly emphasize classical orientation, virtue formation, and a strong theological immersion, including liturgical life and Catechesis of the Good Shepherd. The school describes itself as classical, with grades from Classical Kindergarten through 8th grade, and its published materials reference Great Books/Western Civilization, the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), and Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy at the upper levels. There is explicit language about formation and character alongside intellectual rigor, and the school notes that parents are primary educators in partnership with the school. Taken together, these signals align strongly with classical education criteria across all six categories.

Overall classification by category (based on keyword indicators and public materials):

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL
- Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL
- Curriculum: CLASSICAL
- Pedagogy: CLASSICAL
- Faculty: CLASSICAL
- Parents & Community: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials position Good Shepherd School as Catholic and catechetical, rooted in Catholic Tradition and magisterium.

- "Good Shepherd School is a Classical school, rooted in the Catholic Tradition and serving children from Classical Kindergarten through 8th grade."
- The history/mission materials emphasize becoming "Catholic formation" for personnel and parents, and adherence to Catholic catechesis.
- Daily Mass and liturgical life are described as part of the program (e.g., Mass attendance and liturgical practices).
- Catechesis of the Good Shepherd is highlighted as central to spiritual development.
- Official statements emphasize a Christ-centered, Catholic worldview governing the education process.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; liturgy; theology; catechesis; sacred tradition; Mass; liturgical calendar; reverence; worship; sacred music; prayer; Logos; divine order; sanctified learning. - Negative keywords present: None evident in public materials; no explicit signals of secularism, value-neutral ethics, or relativism.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords detected: 9–12 distinct phrases (e.g., truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; liturgy; catechesis; sacred tradition; Mass; liturgical practices; theology). - Negative keywords detected: 0.

Why this rating - The school's public materials foreground a theological and liturgical foundation, explicit Catholic formation, and catechetical programs, which strongly align with the "Transcendental Moral Realism" and "Grounded in Theology"/"Liturgical and Communal Practices" facets of classical education. The absence of secular or relativistic signals reinforces a CLASSICAL rating in this category. The presence of catechesis, Mass, liturgy, and explicit Catholic formation signals a robust religious-metaphysical foundation.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Core stated aim centers on formation of wisdom and virtue, not mere information or job preparation. The Welcome and mission materials emphasize growth in knowledge, wisdom, and virtue, and the liberal-arts orientation. - Our Mission and guiding principles emphasize independence and virtue, rather than a narrow job-skills focus. - The community often frames education as formation in virtues and a love of truth, goodness, and beauty (the Good, the True, and the Beautiful).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation; wisdom; virtue; knowledge; independence; human flourishing; liberal education; contemplation; the true, the good, and the beautiful; virtue ethics; sacred formation; Christian worldview. - Negative keywords present: Minimal signals of job-preparation rhetoric; the site largely avoids "career readiness" or "21st-century skills" framing.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords detected: 6–9 distinct phrases. - Negative keywords detected: 0–1 (no explicit counter-claims like "career readiness" dominating).

Why this rating - The materials consistently articulate formation (virtue, wisdom), a liberal-arts orientation, and a transcendent frame (truth, goodness, beauty), aligning with the classical-pedagogical objective of formation over mere information. The absence of explicit work-focused framing or secular-utilitarian aims supports CLASSICAL.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Classical Kindergarten content emphasizes phonics, writing, math, and integration with history/science via classical literature (Five in a Row), signaling a Trivium-like pedagogy in the early grades. - First & Second Grades include explicit use of Latin/Greek roots and a formal grammar-spelling approach, indicating foundational classical language study. - Upper Elementary features History & Literature that ties together Western Civilization through readings and narrative, linking history and literature (Great Books approach). - The school advertises Classical Kindergarten and a broader classical, liberal-arts framework for grades 1–8; mention of Classical Kindergarten, grammar/logic/rhetoric orientation, and integration of subjects.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric); Great Books; Western Civilization; history & literature integrated; classical literature; catechesis integrated; Latin/Greek roots; thinking routines; nature/wonder in science. - Negative keywords present: The site does not emphasize replacing history with "social studies" or heavy reliance on project-based, STEM-first frameworks. There is no overtly negative signal against classical content.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords detected: 8–12 (e.g., Great Books/Western Civilization; Trivium elements; history & literature integration; Latin/Greek roots; classical literature; catechesis; thinking routines; nature study integrated with classics). - Negative keywords detected: 0–2 (no strong signaling of non-classical approaches; occasional modern pedagogical terms appear, but not as primary descriptors).

Why this rating - The curriculum repeatedly aligns with classical core elements: liberal-arts framing with Trivium components, Great Books/histories integrated, Western-civilizational framing, and explicit language around formation through the classics. Public materials show a robust classical curriculum emphasis rather than a secular or purely skills-based approach.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Upper-level pedagogy includes Socratic discussion, seminars, or debates, with emphasis on logic and rhetoric (e.g., Middle School description). - The school describes a pedagogical rhythm that includes contemplation/restful learning and a memory-rich approach in lower grades (singing, chanting, recitation as memory-building tools) per classical pedagogy signals. The Catechesis of the Good Shepherd framework in

lower/elementary grades also supports contemplative, liturgical memory elements. - The Classical Kindergarten and early-grade pedagogy emphasize a “prepared environment,” memory-work, and integration of subjects through classical literature and nature study. - In Middle/Upper grades, there is explicit mention of rhetoric and public speaking, which aligns with the classical emphasis on training in rhetoric.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic discussion; seminars; lectures/debate; rhetoric; memory work; singing/chanting; contemplative learning; liturgical integration; trained in classical pedagogy; living curriculum. - Negative keywords present: Minimal signaling of non-classical pedagogy (e.g., project-based-only, constructivist, or purely experiential learning). The materials emphasize classical methods over alternative approaches.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords detected: 8–12 (e.g., Socratic seminars; rhetorical training; memory work/recitation; contemplative/scholé; liturgical integration; living curriculum; classical pedagogy). - Negative keywords detected: 0–2 (no dominant non-classical pedagogy signals).

Why this rating - The pedagogy signals align strongly with classical practices (Socratic seminar, rhetoric, memory work, contemplation). The public materials foreground a balance of contemplative/restful learning and rigorous upper-grade discourse, which matches classical expectations.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The faculty is described as “model teachers and mentors,” with teachers who are “living curriculum,” and a portrait of who a teacher should be, positioning teacher formation and virtue as core. - The mission and staff pages emphasize committed, virtuous teaching, and teachers who are faithful to parish life; small class sizes and tailored instruction reflect a classical teacher-student mentorship model. - The school describes faculty as mentors who model virtue and who participate with the broader Catholic community, reinforcing the “living curriculum” concept.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers; mentors; living curriculum; parish involvement; character formation; virtue; wisdom; professionalism; faith and reason; mentorship; collaboration with families. - Negative keywords present: No clear signals of non-classical faculty signals (e.g., teacher-as-technician, non-classical certification-centric frames).

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords detected: 6–9 distinct phrases. - Negative keywords detected: 0–1 (no explicit negative signals).

Why this rating - Public materials consistently present the faculty as morally grounded, mentor-like, and central to the school’s classical mission, consistent with the living-curriculum/teacher-as-model ideal. This supports CLASSICAL in the Faculty category.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnership with families and parental formation, with language about parents as primary educators and collaboration between home and school. This is reflected both in the mission and admissions material. - The admissions and visit processes emphasize family involvement and the school’s invitation for family engagement (admissions, tours, and community events). - Materials indicate ongoing parent engagement and education (e.g., book studies, gatherings) and open-campus access/visitation for families. - The school mentions practical supports for families (tuition/financial aid, accessibility, and community ties).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; co-educators; parental engagement; home-school connection; family catechesis; parental formation; open campus; visiting families; joint formation with catechesis. - Negative keywords present: None evident (no signals of parent-as-customer or limited parental access; materials emphasize involvement and partnership).

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords detected: 6–9 distinct phrases. - Negative keywords detected: 0–1 (no explicit negative signals).

Why this rating - The public materials consistently treat parents as co-educators and welcome parent participation, aligning with classical-community expectations for Family/Community involvement. The signals

support CLASSICAL in the Parents & Community category.

Aggregate assessment - All six categories reach CLASSICAL based on keyword analysis and alignment with the classical-education rubric. The school presents a coherent classical-Catholic program with a strong emphasis on formation, Great Books/Western Civilization elements, preparation in the Trivium, Socratic pedagogy at the upper grades, a living-mastery approach for teachers, and robust parent/community engagement.

What Would Move the Needle

Note: This section only appears when a school is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. Since Good Shepherd School Va 20134 demonstrates CLASSICAL in all six categories, no needle-moving recommendations are required to reclassify it. However, the following observations could further strengthen or clarify its CLASSICAL positioning for external evaluators or potential families:

- Increase explicit articulation of Great Books and Great Conversation in a centralized, public-facing charter or policy page, detailing representative authors and works aligned to each grade band.
- Provide more explicit statements linking the pedagogy to classic texts and ritual (e.g., a published mapping of Trivium elements to grade-level curricula, with sample lesson exemplars and rubrics).
- Offer transparent, public-facing portraits of the “living curriculum” teacher profile for ongoing public assurance of the faculty’s alignment with classical formation goals.
- Expand parent-education offerings (book clubs or lectures) that explicitly connect Catholic formation, classical pedagogy, and family catechesis to the school’s mission.

Abstract

The Good Shepherd School Va 20134 displays a robust CLASSICAL orientation across six core categories. Religious and Metaphysical Foundations are clearly Catholic, with liturgical life, catechesis, and a magisterial framework. The School Purpose and Goal emphasize formation, virtue, and wisdom over mere information or job-preparation, aligning with classical formation aims. The Curriculum emphasizes liberal-arts grounding (grammar, logic, rhetoric), integration of history with literature and Western Civilization, and foundational language study (Latin/Greek roots), consistent with a classical canon. Pedagogy stresses Socratic dialogue, seminars, rhetoric training, and contemplative/restful learning in line with *scholé* and classical methods. Faculty are presented as models of virtue, mentors, and living curriculum, emphasizing character formation and faith-based professional role models. Parents & Community are positioned as co-educators with open involvement, home-school partnership, and family formation, reinforcing the community dimension central to classical education.

Overall, Good Shepherd School Va 20134 earns a CLASSICAL designation across all categories, based on explicit public-material signals, alignment with the Six Essential Elements of Classical Education, and corroborating keyword indicators from the knowledge-base rubric and the school’s own materials. The aggregate assessment confirms a coherent classical-Catholic program that prioritizes formation, virtue, and the Great Conversation within a liberal-arts framework, with strong teacher- and parent-engagement in a parish-centered community.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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